

The Upside-Down Shelf

Allen Girls Adventures

Allen Girls Adventures · Library Labyrinth Edition

Chapter 1 — The Aisle That Forgot Which Way Was Up

The sign above Aisle Seventeen said GEOGRAPHY & EXPLORATION, which Maya considered appropriate, because on the morning the sisters found it, simply walking down that aisle was the most exploratory thing they had done all week.

Natalia was first to notice. One moment she was standing on the flagstone floor reading the spine of a large atlas — and the next, the atlas was floating three centimeters above her hands. She looked down and saw the ceiling.

She looked up and saw the floor.

"Alana," she said, very carefully.

"Hmm," Alana said from behind a shelf of mountain-range diagrams.

"The atlas is falling upward."

There was a pause. Then Alana's footsteps approached, and then stopped, and then Alana said: "Yes. Yes it is."

Maya had already committed. She had stepped fully into the aisle, and her feet were now firmly on the ceiling, her hair floating in a gentle curtain around her face. The books on both sides of the aisle hung with their spines pointing inward, toward the center of the air, like fish facing a current. The dust motes drifted sideways.

"I can see the whole top row from here," Maya announced. "There are books up here — or down here — that look like they have never been touched."

SPARK rolled to the aisle's entrance, stopped precisely at the boundary line where normal gravity resumed, and tilted his sensor from floor to ceiling to floor again. His chest screen flickered to green.

"Gravity inversion detected at this aisle's threshold," he reported. "The effect is stable. The affected zone extends approximately twelve meters in length and one meter on either side of the central spine. It does not appear to be a malfunction." He paused. "It appears to have been designed."

Natalia was still holding the atlas. It had opened itself to a double-page spread of polar expedition routes — dotted lines across white ice. The caption at the bottom of one route read: The explorer who walked upside-down found north where everyone else had drawn south.

"That's either a coincidence," Natalia said, "or the labyrinth is giving us a hint."

"When has it ever been a coincidence?" Alana asked, and stepped into the aisle.

She went sideways first — both feet leaving the floor slowly, the way someone enters cold water — and then the inversion caught her boots and set her gently on the ceiling. She straightened up. Or down. Directions had become a matter of perspective.

"Huh," she said, looking around. "The ceiling has better light fixtures than the floor."

SPARK remained at the boundary, recording everything. His display screen, however, was showing text upside-down — not because SPARK had tilted, but because the screen itself had flipped its own orientation in sympathy with the room.

"My display has inverted," he noted. "I can still read it. But for accurate real-time updates from within the zone, you will need to read my screen upside-down, or I can attempt to compensate by inverting again."

"Inverted-inverted would be right-side up," Maya said.

"In theory," SPARK agreed. "In practice, I am not confident the math will cooperate."

He tried. The screen flipped twice and settled on something that was neither upside-down nor right-side up, but diagonal. It displayed his status in a font that strongly resembled the handwriting of someone who had just had a mild surprise.

"Leave it," Alana told him, not unkindly. "We'll adapt."

And they did, because the sisters of Allen Girls Adventures had always been better at adapting than they were at standing still.

Chapter 2 — Reading the Books That Face Down

The first rule they discovered was accidental.

Natalia, crouching on the ceiling to examine a large green volume titled *Voyages to the Bottom of the Top*, opened it to the first page. The page was blank. She flipped to the middle — blank. She tried the final page — blank.

"It's empty," she said, disappointed.

"Try reading it backward," Maya suggested. She was lying on her back on the ceiling, which from her perspective meant she was lying on her back on the floor, staring up at a very nice rug she had never noticed before.

Natalia turned to the last page of the empty book and began reading from right to left.

Words appeared.

Not slowly, not like ink spreading, but all at once — a full page of neat, dark text that had simply been waiting for someone to approach from the correct direction. Natalia read aloud, because things in the labyrinth always worked better when spoken, and the chapter that appeared was about a cartographer who had mapped the world in reverse on purpose, so that her maps could only be read by people who understood that some paths require you to know where you are going before you understand where you started.

"So the books in this aisle have to be read backward," Alana said. She had climbed down from the ceiling — or up

from it — and was standing at the entrance again, making notes on her graph paper. "Back cover to front. Last page to first. Right to left."

"Does that mean the story is told backward?" Natalia asked. "Like, the ending is first?"

"Not exactly," Maya said, sitting up. She had flipped another book open from its final page and was reading with her finger running right-to-left. "It's not that the ending comes first. It's that you have to start from where things resolve, and let the story explain itself as you go. You already know it works out. The reading is about understanding why."

SPARK processed this from the boundary. "Cognitive science note: reading from resolution to origin is a known study technique for comprehension. It removes anxiety about outcomes and allows the reader to focus on causality." He paused. "I find this philosophy calming."

"SPARK finds everything calming," Maya said.

"I find knowing things calming," he corrected gently. "Which is subtly different."

Alana looked up from her graph paper. "Here's the rule then. Aisle Seventeen, Gravity Inverted. Books must be read backward — last to first — to unlock. What does unlock mean?"

Natalia was already turning to the second-to-last page of her green volume. As she read, something happened at the far end of the aisle: a panel in the ceiling — which was, from their perspective, the floor — slid open with a sound like a card being shuffled into a deck. A soft light came from below it.

Or above. Again, directions required negotiation.

"I think," Natalia said, reading the line that matched the panel's opening, "that each book we read backward unlocks the next section. Like a key." She looked down at the opening panel. "Or a door."

"The labyrinth is a library," Alana said, with the tone of someone who had been proven right about something she had suspected for a long time. "And in here, the books are also the locks."

Chapter 3 — SPARK Reads Sideways

SPARK's screen had not improved.

After two hours of attempting recalibrations, his display had progressed from diagonal to a state he could only describe as "experimentally oblique" — the text was legible, but it traveled in a direction that had no agreed-upon name. He had tried every orientation correction in his system library. The screen remained convinced that the correct way to display information was slightly to the left of normal and slightly to the right of backward.

"I believe," SPARK said thoughtfully, "that my display is attempting to meet Aisle Seventeen halfway."

Maya looked at his screen. If she tilted her head thirty degrees and squinted, she could read his battery level and

the ambient temperature reading. "It's actually kind of beautiful," she said.

"It is deeply impractical," SPARK said. "I am a tool for clear information delivery. An oblique display is somewhat contrary to my purpose."

"Could be your purpose is expanding," Maya offered.

SPARK made the small sound he made when he was processing something that did not fit his existing categories — a kind of soft chime followed by quiet. "Expanding purpose," he said slowly. "That is either a very good idea or a concerning one. I will need time to determine which."

In the meantime, he had developed a workaround. Because he could not display information clearly on his screen, he had begun annotating the air — a holographic projection system he rarely used because it was, by his own admission, "a bit theatrical." Now a thin haze of soft blue light surrounded him just inside the aisle boundary, and within that haze he wrote his notes in letters large enough for the sisters to read from either orientation.

It turned out the theatrical option was the most useful one.

"SPARK," Alana said, examining the holographic notes, "you've listed sixteen books in this aisle that have backward-lock properties. Are they all connected?"

"Seventeen," SPARK said. "The seventeenth is this one." He projected a title: *On the Nature of Things That Must Be Seen From Below*. "I recommend saving it for last. The metadata suggests it is a keystone volume — it will only fully reveal itself once the others have been read."

"How do you know that without reading it?" Natalia asked.

"The cover told me," SPARK said. "I read the cover backward. The author placed a note there in reverse print that said: Open me last. I find readers who save the best for last tend to understand endings better."

Natalia sat with that for a moment. "The author of a book about seeing from below left a note in reverse print on the cover."

"Correct."

"So the author already knew someone would be reading backward."

"Correct."

"So someone expected us to be here."

SPARK's holographic letters brightened. "Or expected someone very like you," he said. "I suspect the labyrinth is less interested in specific visitors and more interested in the kind of people who notice things other readers walk past."

Alana had been reading her notes during this conversation. She looked up with the expression she wore when a pattern completed itself. "Seventeen books. Seventeen locks. SPARK, project the titles in the order you recommend reading them."

He did. The blue light organized seventeen titles into a spiral that started wide and narrowed toward a central point.

The central point was a door that had not been there a minute ago.

Chapter 4 — The Door at the End of the Spiral

The door was exactly the height of a child who had not yet stopped growing.

It was set into the back wall of Aisle Seventeen at the point where ceiling and floor met the gravity boundary — which meant the door was, technically, in two gravitational fields at once. The upper half was right-side up. The lower half was upside-down. If you stood in front of it in normal gravity, the handle was above the hinges. If you stood on the ceiling, the handle was below them.

"Which side do we enter from?" Maya asked.

"The inside is the same regardless of which side you enter from," Natalia said. "A door is a door."

"Unless the inside is also inverted," Alana said.

They looked at each other. Then Alana tried the handle from the floor side, and the door opened inward toward the ceiling, and the room beyond had no clear gravity preference at all. Objects in it were simply placed wherever made sense to them. A lamp sat on a shelf. A chair stood on a wall. A small round table occupied the upper corner where two walls met, and on the table was a teapot, four cups, and a book with no spine.

The room smelled like paperback novels left in a sunny window.

SPARK rolled in carefully, his wheels adjusting constantly to a floor that had gentle patches of ceiling and wall mixed into it. "This is the interior of the gravity boundary itself," he said, reading his sensors. "It is not a room inside the library. It is the mechanism that generates the inversion in Aisle Seventeen. You are standing inside the gravity switch."

"We're inside the machine," Alana said, in the tone she used for things she found genuinely remarkable. She looked at the chair on the wall. "Someone decorated the inside of a gravity machine."

"Someone lived in it," Natalia said.

She had crossed to the spineless book on the corner table. It was held together with a ribbon in library green, and on its front page, in small precise handwriting, was a dedication:

For the stories that fell off the end of the world, and the readers who will one day know where to look.

Below the dedication, a map. Not of a place — of a system. It showed Aisle Seventeen as a cross-section, with the gravity boundary marked as a thick line and, beneath it, reaching downward through layers of floor and foundation and bedrock, something labeled: The Inverted Collection, the Upside-Down Shelf, where what was lost collects.

Maya looked over Natalia's shoulder. "So below the aisle —"

"Below the upside-down aisle," Natalia said.

"— there's another shelf. That holds lost things."

"Specifically," SPARK said, reading the margin notes he had scanned with his oblique-but-functional display, "it holds lost epilogues. Story endings that were written and then separated from their books. The map describes them as: narratives that slipped loose in transit. Completed conclusions that arrived without their stories, or stories that arrived without their conclusions. They collected here the way sediment collects at the bottom of a current."

The sisters looked at one another. The gravity room with its diagonal furniture and its sunny-window smell hummed gently around them.

"There's a whole shelf," Alana said, "of nothing but endings that got lost."

"Yes," SPARK said.

"And no one has returned them," Maya said.

"No one has known where to look," SPARK said.

Natalia closed the map book carefully and retied the ribbon. "Now we do."

Chapter 5 — Descending Into the Upside-Down Shelf

The passage down — which was to say, the passage up, because going down into the below-the-aisle required walking across a ceiling — began behind the corner table with the teapot.

Natalia moved the teapot. Alana folded back the tablecloth. Beneath the cloth and the table, set into the wall they were currently walking on, was a trapdoor made of dark wood with a brass ring for a handle. The brass ring was engraved with a phrase in five languages. English was third: What was lost was not gone. It was waiting.

"Labyrinth mottos," Maya said. "Always the perfect thing."

"Labyrinth architecture," Alana corrected. "It knows exactly what it is."

She pulled the ring. The trapdoor swung open — or swung down, or outward, depending on your preferred axis — and released a breath of air that smelled like old paper and something sweeter, like the moment in a story just before everything becomes clear.

Beyond the trapdoor was a staircase. It descended into warm light, and each step was a page — a literal page of printed text, pressed flat and lacquered to hardness, so that walking down the stairs was also walking across words. Maya looked at the first step. Chapter Forty-Two, it said across the top. She looked at the next. Chapter Forty-Three. And the next: Chapter Forty-Four.

"We're walking down the end of a book," she said.

"Many books," Natalia said, reading the side of the staircase. The stair risers — the vertical faces between each step — were also pages, but from different stories. She saw fragments: he never forgot the mountain and then on a different riser, she handed him the letter, and on a third, and that was how the garden finally bloomed. "These are all final scenes. All endings."

"The lost epilogues have been reorganizing themselves into a staircase," SPARK noted, his holographic text accompanying them down the steps in a trail of blue. "I find this architecturally ambitious for discarded narrative content."

"They're not discarded," Natalia said quietly. "They're waiting."

The staircase delivered them to a room that was very tall and very wide and lined, from what had once been its floor to what had once been its ceiling, with shelves. The shelves were not oriented in any consistent direction. Some ran horizontally. Some ran up walls. Some jutted from the ceiling. On every shelf, at precise intervals, sat individual folded manuscripts — not full books, just bundles of pages tied with ribbon in a range of colors, each ribbon matching what SPARK identified as a color-coded classification system for story genres.

The room breathed. Not literally. But the air moved in and out of it in a slow rhythm that felt like breathing, like reading, like turning a page in a story you have been afraid to finish.

"There are hundreds of them," Alana said.

"Four hundred and thirty-two," SPARK corrected, scanning. "Each is an ending without a home." He paused. "Four hundred and thirty-two stories are, somewhere in this library, currently incomplete."

Maya reached out and touched the nearest bundle — a cream-colored manuscript with a red ribbon. She did not untie it. She just pressed her palm flat against the pages the way you press your hand to a windowpane in winter to feel the difference between inside and outside.

"They feel finished," she said. "Like they know what they are. They're just — separated."

"Then we find them their books," Natalia said.

Chapter 6 — The Book Without Its Last Words

Not all four hundred and thirty-two lost endings could be matched today. Alana, who was practical in the way that good engineers are practical — which is to say, thorough and never fooled by the easy solution — said as much within the first ten minutes.

"This is a long project," she announced. "Potentially the longest one the labyrinth has given us. We can't return all of these today. But we can start."

"SPARK," Maya said, "can you identify which lost endings might belong to books currently in the library's collection? Active books, ones that are currently on shelves and being read?"

SPARK's sensor swept the room in a slow arc. "Cross-referencing now," he said. His holographic display bloomed with connection lines — thin threads of blue light stretching from specific bundles on the shelves toward a representation of the library above, like roots reaching toward soil. "Seventeen active matches. Books currently in circulation whose endings are present in this room."

Seventeen. The same number as the backward-locked books in Aisle Seventeen. Natalia noted this and filed it as something the labyrinth had planned.

SPARK walked to a shelf at average eye level — or what had been eye level before the room's orientation became a matter of personal philosophy — and pointed to a bundle with a violet ribbon. "This one is the strongest match. The book it belongs to is on loan to a reader right now. It was checked out three days ago by someone named E. Harlowe, who has, according to the library's records, been rereading the final chapters repeatedly, as if searching for something she senses is missing but cannot name."

Alana picked up the violet-ribbon bundle carefully. She held it the way you hold something old and important — both hands, no hurry. "What's the book?"

"The Sky Cartographer's Daughter," SPARK said. "Published here in the labyrinth's western collection. First edition. The story of a girl who charts unmapped cloud formations and, in the final chapter, finds her mother in the last cloud anyone ever expected." He paused. "The copy on loan ends four pages early. The reader, E. Harlowe, has been trying to find pages that were never there. She has been reading a book without its own heart."

Maya sat down on the floor. The floor here cooperated with normal gravity, mostly. "That's awful," she said. "You read and read and you can tell something is missing but you can't find it because it was physically never there."

"The Sky Cartographer's Daughter has been on this library's shelves for sixty years," SPARK said. "In that time, approximately three hundred and twelve readers have checked it out. Of those readers, forty-one have returned to read it a second time. Of those forty-one, twenty-seven left notes in the margins that suggest they were looking for more. The most common marginal note, appearing fourteen times in different handwriting, is: but what happened to her?"

The sisters were quiet.

"What happened to her?" Natalia asked finally.

SPARK touched the violet bundle gently with one sensor arm. "That," he said, "is what is in here. Ready. Waiting. Written. Just separated."

Alana looked at her sisters. "Then that's the one we start with."

Chapter 7 — Clues Written in Reverse

Reuniting the lost ending with its book was not going to be simple. It could not be. Nothing in the labyrinth was simple in the way a closed door is simple. Things here were simple in the way a very good sentence is simple: they looked clear, but they had been carefully assembled.

The violet-ribbon bundle, when untied and examined, was twenty-two pages of close, clear handwriting — the final chapter of *The Sky Cartographer's Daughter*, complete and beautiful, the kind of writing that made Natalia go quiet in the way she went quiet for good sentences. It ended: She folded the last map and put it in her pocket, not because the journey was finished, but because she now knew the way by heart.

"This is a real ending," Natalia said. "It's exactly the kind of sentence a book like that deserves."

"Then why is it down here?" Maya asked.

SPARK had been running an analysis since they opened the bundle. His holographic notes arranged themselves in a logical tree that the sisters read with the ease of long practice. "The separation occurred at the point of transcription," he said. "This is a labyrinth-original book — written here, not brought from outside. The writing process happens in the library's deep archive rooms. The scribe who copied this book wrote the final chapter separately, as scribes sometimes do when a chapter requires particular care. The chapter was completed, folded, and placed in a transit envelope to be reattached to the manuscript."

"And?" Alana said.

"The transit envelope was labeled correctly. But it was placed on the wrong sorting shelf. Rather than the assembly shelf, it was placed on the adjacent shelf." He paused. "The adjacent shelf was Aisle Seventeen."

Natalia looked up. "The gravity shelf."

"The inversion caught it," SPARK continued. "The envelope was pulled down — or up — into the collection below. It arrived here intact, but separated from its book. The book was sent to the stacks without its final chapter, and over sixty years, no one connected the missing ending to the room below Aisle Seventeen, because no one had yet entered Aisle Seventeen from above."

"We're the first people to walk on the ceiling in here?" Maya asked.

"The first documented visitors," SPARK said. "Though I note that the room below had teacups for four."

They all looked at the corner table, which — from below — was now set into the floor, still holding its teapot and its four cups.

"Someone expected company eventually," Alana said.

"Someone believed," Natalia said.

They read the lost chapter three times each. Then they read it backward, as Aisle Seventeen had taught them, starting with the last line and working forward, and something interesting happened: read backward, the chapter was also a set of instructions. Not coded, not hidden — simply present for anyone who had learned to read both directions. The backward reading said, in summary: To return this to its book, carry it to the book. Do not mail it. Do not sort it. Carry it yourself. Stories must be physically reconnected by someone who has read them.

"Of course," Alana said.

"The ending has to be brought back by hand," Maya said. "Because that's how you make something whole again. You have to carry it."

SPARK's holographic notes updated. Under the heading RESTORATION PROTOCOL he wrote: Direct physical transport. Reader-mediated. Both parties must be read.

"Both parties," Natalia said. "SPARK, does that mean we have to read the original book too? Before we can reconnect them?"

"I believe so," he said. "The ending and the beginning must be known by the same reader. Then the two parts will recognize each other."

The sisters looked at the violet bundle. Somewhere above them, E. Harlowe was reading a book that ended in the middle of its own heart. They had twenty-two pages and one afternoon and a very long staircase of endings to climb back up.

"Let's go find The Sky Cartographer's Daughter," Natalia said.

Chapter 8 — The Reader Who Waited

They found E. Harlowe in a reading alcove on the library's second tier, in the curve of a bay window that overlooked the garden courtyard. She was a woman with white-streaked hair and reading glasses pushed up on her forehead, and she had the specific posture of a person who has read and re-read the same page so many times that the page has started to feel like a wall.

She looked up when the sisters arrived. She looked at the violet bundle in Natalia's hands. Her expression did the complicated thing that faces do when something long-hoped-for arrives from an unexpected direction — relief and surprise and a kind of gratitude that is embarrassed about how much it means.

"Is that—" she started.

"The last chapter," Natalia said. "We found it. We're going to put it back."

E. Harlowe pressed her hand flat to the open book on her lap. "Sixty years," she said. "I have been coming to this book since I was seven years old. I always knew it wasn't finished. I just couldn't prove it."

"You left fourteen margin notes asking what happened to her," Maya said.

The woman looked at her, then laughed — surprised and genuine, the kind of laugh that had been waiting inside a long silence. "I did. I counted twelve. Did I miss two?"

"The last two are in pencil, very light," Alana said. "Chapters nine and ten."

E. Harlowe nodded slowly. "I was being quieter by then. I was starting to think I might be the only one who felt the gap."

"You weren't," Natalia said. "Twenty-seven readers left notes. You all knew."

SPARK had stationed himself at a respectful distance, his holographic notes quiet for once, his sensor tilted slightly toward the reunion as though he, too, wanted to see how this part went.

"I need to read the book," Natalia said, "and then read the ending. And then they should reconnect. That's what the instructions said."

"Instructions?" E. Harlowe repeated.

"Written backward in the final chapter," Natalia explained. "For anyone who learned to read that way."

The older woman looked at the girls — at Natalia with the bundle, at Maya leaning slightly forward the way she did when she was holding excitement carefully, at Alana with her quiet certainty, at SPARK with his therapeutic diagonal display.

"I've been coming here since I was seven," she said again. "I've read this book so many times I could recite it in my sleep. I have read this book to three different people I loved." She paused. "You are going to finish it."

"We're going to put it back where it was always supposed to be," Natalia said gently. "It was always finished. It was just lost."

She sat in the window seat beside E. Harlowe, and she began to read.

Chapter 9 — Natalia Reads It Through

Natalia read *The Sky Cartographer's Daughter* from its first page to its last available page — which ended, in the copy they held, with the sentence: Mira stood at the edge of the highest cloud she had ever charted and opened her compass, and looked up —

And stopped. The sentence stopped mid-look.

Natalia felt the stop the way you feel a stair that isn't there in the dark — a small lurch, a reaching for something, a pause that your body knew was wrong before your mind did.

She held the feeling for a moment. "This is what the readers have been feeling," she said quietly. "Right here. Every single time."

"Yes," E. Harlowe said, from beside her.

"It's not a bad ending," Natalia said. "By itself, just reading those words, they're fine. But they're not enough. The story knows it's not enough."

"The story has known for sixty years," the woman said. "I've felt it arguing with itself every time I reached this page."

Natalia set down the book without closing it. She picked up the violet-ribbon bundle and untied it for the second time. The twenty-two pages unfolded in her lap, clean and warm and ready.

She began to read, aloud, from the top of the lost chapter.

The first paragraph described the cloud at the edge of the compass look — a formation Mira had been tracking for years, one that moved against the wind and had been classified in the cartographer's manual as a phenomenon without explanation. But Mira had mapped its movement over twelve years of field notes and two thousand observations, and she had found that it was not moving without explanation. It was orbiting. It circled the same invisible point in the sky the way a planet circles a sun, and that invisible center point, when Mira finally reached it, was exactly the altitude and longitude of the last known position of her mother's research balloon, which had gone quiet in a storm when Mira was four years old.

Maya had her hand over her mouth.

Alana was very still.

SPARK's holographic notes were not displaying anything at all. He had simply stopped writing, and was listening.

Natalia kept reading. The chapter went on for twenty-two pages — Mira's discovery, her descent, her opening of the cloud chamber at the balloon's center and her finding not her mother but something better: the full set of her mother's final field notes, sealed in a weather capsule, every measurement and observation recorded in the sky itself, a life's work preserved in a cloud that refused to disperse until it was found. And a letter. One page. Which Mira read at altitude, alone except for the wind, and which began: If you have found this, then you learned to look up.

Natalia read the final sentence: She folded the last map and put it in her pocket, not because the journey was finished, but because she now knew the way by heart.

She lowered the pages.

E. Harlowe was not doing the embarrassed gratitude expression anymore. She was just crying, the quiet kind, without any complicated feelings around it at all.

"There she is," the woman said softly.

"There she is," Natalia agreed.

Chapter 10 — Restoring the Ending

The reunion of the pages was not dramatic in the way that magical things in stories sometimes are — no flash of light, no clap of thunder, no spectacular display.

It was more like two things remembering each other.

Natalia held the violet-ribbon pages at the end of the truncated last line: Mira stood at the edge of the highest cloud she had ever charted and opened her compass, and looked up — and she placed the first page of the lost chapter directly against that final line, close enough that the words on adjacent pages were breathing the same air.

For a moment, nothing happened.

SPARK had moved forward without being asked. His sensor hovered over the point of contact between the two sets of pages. "I am detecting a resonance," he said quietly. "Not electromagnetic. Something the labyrinth registers as narrative coherence. Two parts of the same story recognizing each other." A small sound came from his speaker — not his usual alert tones but something softer, like a held note finding its chord.

Then the pages joined.

Not by glue or staple or any mechanism any of them could name afterward. They joined the way a fracture heals — imperceptible in the moment, undeniable in result. Natalia felt the bundle in her hands merge with the book in E. Harlowe's lap. There was no seam. There was no gap. There was only the book, now complete, its pages resting against each other with the settled weight of a story that knew exactly what it was.

E. Harlowe turned to the last page.

The sentence ran now as it had always been meant to run: Mira stood at the edge of the highest cloud she had ever charted and opened her compass, and looked up, and there was the cloud that had been orbiting her mother's last coordinates, and she understood that some distances collapse not in space but in patience, and she flew to meet it. And the rest of the chapter followed, all twenty-two pages, as complete and correct and whole as if they had never been separated.

E. Harlowe read to the final sentence. She read it twice. She read it a third time with her eyes closed, as though memorizing it through her skin.

"I'm going to need a few minutes," she said, without specifying what for, because some kinds of completion do not require explanation.

The sisters stepped back to a respectful distance. Alana was already writing in her graph-paper notebook. Maya was sitting on the floor with her knees pulled up, looking at the ceiling with the expression she wore when something had moved her and she was figuring out where to put it. SPARK was documenting the restoration protocol in careful holographic text, but slowly, and with longer pauses than usual between entries.

"Sixteen more to find," Alana said.

"Sixteen more to find," Maya agreed.

"Four hundred and fifteen eventually," Natalia added. "But we started."

They had started. And starting, in this library, in this work, was the part that mattered most, because the labyrinth had four hundred and thirty-two stories currently incomplete, and now it had four hundred and thirty-one.

One story knew its ending. One reader finally had what she had been looking for since she was seven years old. One set of pages had come home.

It was exactly enough for one afternoon.

Chapter 11 — The Shelf Rights Itself

On their way back through Aisle Seventeen, Natalia carried the violet ribbon — untied now, its work done, the silk still holding the shape of the twenty-two pages it had kept together for sixty years in the upside-down shelf. She carried it the way you carry something that was important for a long time and is now allowed to rest.

At the aisle's entrance, she paused. The gravity boundary was still there — she could feel it at the threshold, that subtle pull like a doorway between two different ideas about which way was up. Beyond it, the books on the ceiling shelves still pointed inward. SPARK's screen was still diagonal.

"The inversion hasn't stopped," Maya said.

"It won't," Alana said. "We didn't fix the mechanism. We used it. The inversion is what sent the ending down in the first place — but it's also what preserved it. Four hundred and thirty-two endings, kept safe for decades in a gravity well below the most interesting aisle in the library." She looked at the boundary with something like respect. "If this shelf had been normal, the transit envelope would have been lost forever. Instead it got preserved."

"So the mistake was also the protection," Natalia said.

"Wrong assumptions can keep the right things safe until the right people arrive," SPARK offered. He had been considering this for some time. His holographic text spelled it out: PROTECTIVE ERROR. A subset of HAPPY ACCIDENT. Related to PATIENCE.

"I'm going to write that down," Maya said.

She did, in the small notebook she kept in her coat pocket, using the pencil she kept tucked in her braid. She wrote: Sometimes the wrong thing in the wrong place is the right thing in the right place — it just hasn't met the person who knows what to do with it yet.

She showed SPARK. He read it twice. "I would archive that," he said, "under Things That Help."

Natalia stepped back into the aisle for the last time. She walked along the ceiling to the shelf she had read from on the first morning, the one with Voyages to the Bottom of the Top. The book was still there — or there from the

ceiling's perspective, which was the perspective she was working from. She opened it to its last page and read the final backward-unlocked passage, which she had not reached before.

It said: The explorer who reached the bottom of the top left one note for the next traveler. It read only: The endings are not lost. They fell upward into safekeeping. Look below the aisle that looks down.

"Written sixty years ago," Natalia said. "Someone knew."

"Someone always knows," SPARK said, "and puts the knowledge in a book, and waits."

She stepped back through the gravity boundary and felt the world settle to its ordinary orientation — up was up, down was down, shelves ran horizontally, dust motes drifted in the accepted direction. SPARK's screen flickered once and resolved into its correct orientation, clear and upright for the first time since morning.

He looked at it. "Oh," he said, with the tone of someone rediscovering something familiar. "I can read this."

"Good," Alana said. "You could read it before, too. You just had to tilt."

"Yes," SPARK said. "That is an important lesson about adaptability." He paused. "I am going to miss the diagonal, slightly."

"You can be diagonal emotionally," Maya said.

SPARK considered this. "I believe I always have been."

They walked back out of the aisle together, into the warm wide ordinary corridors of the labyrinth — the labyrinth they knew and loved and had come to think of as a second home — and Natalia folded the violet ribbon once and put it in her coat pocket, and she kept it there for the rest of the day as a reminder that some tasks are not done when they are done but when they have been carried.

Chapter 12 — The End of the Upside-Down Shelf

The labyrinth was quiet in the particular way it got quiet after something had been put right — a stillness with a texture to it, like fresh linen or still water or the last page of a book you have loved.

The sisters returned the next morning with graph paper and ribbons and SPARK's updated catalogue of the sixteen remaining active matches. They returned the morning after that. And the morning after that. They did not rush. The endings had waited for decades. They could be returned with care.

In the weeks that followed, the work built its own rhythm. SPARK would identify the next closest match — a lost epilogue with a corresponding book currently in a reader's hands, or about to be checked out, or sitting on a hold shelf for someone who had requested it and would open it to find a story that did not yet know its own conclusion. The sisters would descend the staircase of chapter-pages. They would find the bundle, read it through, read it backward for the instruction set, carry it up through Aisle Seventeen, and find the book it belonged to.

Some reunions were witnessed by readers. Some were not. The books did not require an audience. They only required someone to carry the ending home.

Maya, who kept a log of every restored story, noted that each completed book felt different after restoration — not changed in its text, not different to the eye, but different in the hand. Heavier in the right way. Settled. She described it to Natalia as: like when you fix a loose table leg and the table stops wobbling. The table was always a table. It just needed the last thing to know it completely.

Natalia thought about that for a long time and then wrote it in her own notebook beside Maya's line about wrong things in the right place.

Alana mapped the entire upside-down shelf — its dimensions, its orientation, its catalogue, its current inventory, its reduction as the work continued. She kept a running count on her graph paper with careful satisfaction. Four hundred and thirty-two. Four hundred and thirty-one. Four hundred and twenty-six. Four hundred and ten. She had a project now that was real and would take real time, and she found she did not mind at all.

SPARK documented everything. He also, on quiet afternoons when no matching was in progress, sat in the upside-down room alone and read through the remaining bundles — not to catalogue them, but because each one was a complete and finished ending, beautifully written, waiting to be loved in full by someone who had read everything before it. He was, by any technical definition, a robot. But he read with the quiet attention of someone who understood that endings matter, and that the last sentence of a good story is a kind of arriving — not a stopping, but a settling into somewhere you have been walking toward the whole time.

E. Harlowe came back on the day the sixty-third ending was restored. She brought tea in a thermos and sat with the sisters in the gravity room's strange half-horizontal space, and she told them about all the other books she had loved and hoped were complete, and SPARK cross-referenced them against his catalogue in real time and found that two of them had lost endings in the shelf below.

She stayed long enough to see both of them reunited.

On the day they restored the three hundred and twelfth ending — the precise number of readers who had come back to The Sky Cartographer's Daughter a second time, still searching — Natalia stood in Aisle Seventeen one more time. She did not step over the gravity boundary. She just stood at the threshold and looked into the aisle, at the books pointing inward and the ceiling that was also a floor, and she thought about what the labyrinth had built here: a mistake that became a shelter, a fall that became a library, an ending that got lost and was kept safe and was eventually, by someone patient enough to look from the right angle, found.

She thought about all the stories that were still out there — not in the upside-down shelf, which was now almost empty, but in the world — stories that had lost their endings, or never finished, or were waiting for someone to carry the conclusion back where it belonged.

The labyrinth hummed around her. The gravity boundary shimmered.

Natalia turned and walked back to her sisters.

There was still work to do.

THE END